IWG Seminar chapter challenge

This year's challenge was trickier than ever, with the teams given the task of creating a bike

As with most of the IWG seminars, a special chapter challenge was set. This year's task was to create a bike. A collaborative challenge, it involved lots of team work and, yes, lots of turning, although plenty of other skills were tested depending on which bike the participating chapters opted to make. Each of the eight finished bikes was stunning in its own way and they were all put on show in the hotel lobby. The display attracted huge amounts of interest from the hotel's visitors and guests, with many sending pictures to friends and loved ones in far-flung places around the world. It was excellent publicity.

As for my part, there isn't much that causes me to become vexed about things, but when Colwin Way and I were asked to judge the Chapter Challenge Collaborative competition this caused me some, shall we say, trepidation.

I am wary of being asked to judge or pick winners. Deciding what wins – and what does not – is always hard. People have put a lot of time and effort into making something and had the guts to submit it for a competition – many do not enter anything in any showing of work, let alone competitions. Then along comes someone who has been asked to make a decision based on various criteria. I was at least glad not to be judging on my own.

LET JUDGING COMMENCE

Colwin and I set about doing our duty of trying to select a winner for this chapter challenge. I had never heard of such a challenge for a seminar. I know there have been amazing collaborative comps around the world before, but bikes? Well, to say there was a glorious display is an understatement. They were all stunning in their own way.

Anyway, it is fair to say that as Colwin and I pored over all the entries we noted exquisite detail from the laminated wheels, tyres and mudguards to the frame, handlebars and the bike chains and so much more. We were on our hands and knees touching and inspecting and in truth delighted in the detail. Sadly, we also had to find things that weren't quite right so that we could come to a conclusion as to which entry should win. I must admit to finding it almost disrespectful. There was a huge amount of time, effort and hard work put into the bikes – in designing, planning what goes where, working how to do it – let alone the precision required and to what scale. Simply stunning!

Members of the South East Chapter, who meet in County Kilkenny in the province of Leinster, were riding high after winning the challenge

Well, after thoroughly checking every entry and much discussion, Colwin and I finally decided on the bike made by the South East Chapter, which meets in County Kilkenny in the province of Leinster.

Congratulations to them, but all the teams deserve much credit. Their bikes, displayed in the hotel lobby, were a real talking point. The turning community needs such attention to further people's knowledge and understanding of our work and this was wonderful publicity.

The winning bike by the South East Chapter was based on the Raleigh Model 31, produced in the early 1940s

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